

Wallace was also in the race, running as a third party candidate with Vietnam veteran General Curtis LeMay as his running mate. Wallace would have one of the strongest third party campaigns in US history, carrying the southern states of Arkansas, Alabama, Mississippi, Louisiana, and Georgia.

On the other side of the race, former vice president Richard Nixon faced stiff competition from three high-profile Republican governors: Ronald Reagan, Nelson Rockefeller, and George Romney.

The blowback from Tet and mounting opposition within his own party contributed mightily to President Johnson announcing on March 31 that he would not seek reelection. Less than a week later, Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. was assassinated in Memphis, plunging the nation into one of its deepest crises since World War II.

“These are **not ordinary times** and this is **not an ordinary election.**”

ROBERT F. KENNEDY ANNOUNCING HIS CANDIDACY, MARCH 16, 1968

Wave of chaos

Violence erupted in 60 cities across the US in the wake of King’s assassination, with a wave of protests and riots that coincided with rising antiwar sentiment, especially on college campuses. New York’s Columbia University was paralyzed by a student sit-in that mixed antiwar and civil rights sentiments. It ended with the arrest of more than 700 students.

By early summer, Kennedy had emerged as the favorite to capture the Democratic nomination and face presumptive Republican nominee Nixon. Robert Kennedy’s assassination on June 6—on the heels of his victory in the California primary—threw the election and the nation into bedlam again. The protests spilled over into the August conventions. As Nixon was officially named as the Republican candidate, protesters rioted in the streets of Miami. Meanwhile, Hubert H. Humphrey emerged as the Democratic candidate in the midst of violence around the convention hall in Chicago.

The Chicago riots tipped the election in favor of the Republican candidate. Although the margin was close (around half a million votes out of 73 million cast), Nixon eventually defeated Humphrey in the November general election, ending one of the most convulsive and violent periods in American political history.